powers, the Qing had restricted trade to Canton. While there was a tremendous demand for Chinese goods—silk, porcelain and tea—the Chinese were quite self-sufficient and there was no demand for western goods. Qing trade regulations meant that the British and other European traders had to pay for their goods in silver. This created a huge imbalance in trade, resulting in the British flooding Canton with Indian-grown opium. The subsequent Opium Wars (1839-1842 and 1856-1860) further reduced the Qing's ability to deal with internal disturbances such as the Taiping Rebellion (1848-1865).

With the Qing preoccupied with the British, the Tibetans fought wars with Zorawar Singh's Dogras and the Ladakhis in 1841-1842 and with Nepal in 1855-56 without any Chinese assistance. Even the subsequent war with Nepal in 1855-56 saw no Chinese involvement, despite the fact that the Tibetans were forced to pay Nepal an annual tribute and accept a Nepalese resident in Lhasa.

Towards the end of the nineteenth century, the British were the dominant power to the south of Tibet as a string of Himalayan kingdoms (including Nepal and Sikkim) were defeated by them and came under their influence. In their subsequent relations with Tibet, the British would play a major part in hyphenating it with China even after the Qing dynasty was ousted and the Tibetans declared themselves outside the purview of Chinese suzerainty. This factor was to be the biggest contradiction in Britain's Tibet policy, where it dealt directly with the Tibetan government to achieve its ends, but had to constantly turn to China to legitimize them.

All the while there was never any doubt that Tibet was an independent country with its own identity. Even after 1720, at no stage did the Qing dynasty actually try and annex or occupy Tibet. If the threat to the Chinese from the Dzungar Mongols had not been there, it is quite likely that the Chinese would have left Tibet completely to itself. China had already brought under its administrative control the territories that it wanted. As for the southern frontier of Tibet that bordered the Indian subcontinent, the Chinese had little or no interest in it.

After the Bhutanese invasion of Cooch Behar and the subsequent Gorkha invasion of Tibet in 1791-92, it would take the British another hundred years to firm up their Tibet policy. By 1899, the time Lord Curzon was Governor-General of India, British thinking could be summed up in a single statement he made: 'Chinese suzerainty over Tibet is a fiction, a